BONUS 2 · INTERNOMICS

The Situation Diagnosis Matrix

Internomics: How to See the Game Behind Every Interaction

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The Situation Diagnosis Matrix

Bonus 2 · 25 common situations, the game behind each one, and what to do

When the same problem keeps coming back, it’s usually a game problem. Not a people problem. Find the situation that sounds like yours and ask the question. Try the move. Then watch what happens and update your read of the game.

The eleven models at a glance

1 See the Game · 2 See the Payoffs · 3 Think in Responses · 4 Manage Predictability · 5 See the Equilibrium · 6 Map Information & Beliefs · 7 Separate Words From Credibility · 8 Commitment Changes the Game · 9 The Shadow of the Future · 10 Diagnose the Coordination Problem · 11 Change the Game

At Work & Leading Teams

1. “Every meeting ends with agreement and nothing changes”

The game behind it	Model 10: Diagnose the Coordination Problem — Nobody opposes the action. The group simply never built a shared expectation about who does it. It’s the project nobody owned.
Ask yourself	Does everyone know who does what by when? And does everyone know that everyone knows?
Try this move	Close every meeting by saying each action out loud with one owner and one date. Send that list to the whole room.
If that doesn’t work	Model 11: Change the Game. Check what the system rewards. If follow-through earns no credit and dropping it costs nothing, fix the structure instead of calling another meeting.

2. “My team only brings me problems at the last minute”

The game behind it	Model 9: The Shadow of the Future — Your team has learned what happens when they bring bad news. Your words said “tell me early.” Your past reactions may have said something else.
Ask yourself	What did I do the last time someone brought me a problem early?
Try this move	The next time someone flags a problem early, thank them first. Then work the problem with them. No blame in that moment.
If that doesn’t work	Model 5: See the Equilibrium. Look at the full loop. Maybe raising a problem means you take it over or add more checks. Ask what would make early reporting the easy choice for them.

3. “I keep asking people to collaborate and they still guard their own turf”

The game behind it	Model 11: Change the Game — They heard you. But if the rewards go to whoever beats their colleagues, guarding turf is the smart response. That’s a design problem. Not a communication problem.
Ask yourself	How could a smart player maximize this payoff without giving me what I really want?
Try this move	Tie part of the reward to shared results. Make helping visible. Give credit for it in public.
If that doesn’t work	Model 2: See the Payoffs. Ask people privately what helping actually costs them. Time? Credit? Risk? Remove the biggest cost first.

4. “The same person keeps interrupting me in meetings”

The game behind it	Model 4: Manage Predictability — You let it go a few times. Now they’ve learned that interrupting you has no cost. You never chose that rule. Your pattern created it.
Ask yourself	What has my reaction taught them to expect?
Try this move	Hold your point calmly. “Let me finish this thought. Then I want to hear yours.” Do it the same way every time. Predictability works for you here.
If that doesn’t work	Model 3: Think in Responses. Talk to them privately and ask what’s driving it. Maybe they fear they won’t get airtime. A clear turn for them may end the race.

5. “Nobody takes initiative. Everything waits for me.”

The game behind it	Model 5: See the Equilibrium — You ask why nobody takes initiative. They think “Because whenever we do, we get overridden.” Each side’s behavior keeps the other in place.
Ask yourself	What happened the last time someone decided without me?
Try this move	Name one area where their call stands. Then let it stand even when you’d have done it differently.
If that doesn’t work	Model 6: Map Information & Beliefs. Maybe they don’t know where the line is. Make decision rights explicit and shared. “You decide up to here. Tell me after.”

Negotiation & Sales

6. “They keep pushing for one more concession”

The game behind it	Model 4: Manage Predictability — Your concessions follow a pattern. They don’t need to know your bottom line. They only need to know you’ll move again. Your pattern tells them there’s more room.
Ask yourself	What has my concession pattern told them?
Try this move	Stop giving moves away for free. Trade instead. “I can do that if you can do this.”
If that doesn’t work	Model 8: Commitment Changes the Game. If your limit is real then say what truly binds it. “Anything past this needs board approval” changes their decision. Only say it if it’s true.

7. “I need to think about it”

The game behind it	Model 6: Map Information & Beliefs — “Think about it” can mean many things. A price concern. A trust gap. Someone else’s approval. A competitor they already prefer. You don’t know which yet.
Ask yourself	What do they know or believe that I don’t?
Try this move	Respect it and ask one honest question. “Of course. What would you want to be sure of before you decide?” Then listen.
If that doesn’t work	Model 1: See the Game. Maybe the decision isn’t theirs alone. Ask who else weighs in. Offer what that person would need to make a clear choice.

8. “This is our final offer. I need an answer by tomorrow.”

The game behind it	Model 8: Commitment Changes the Game — A deadline only binds if something actually binds it. Are they constrained? Or simply saying they are?
Ask yourself	What happens to them if I say no tomorrow?
Try this move	Ask calmly. “Help me understand what happens after tomorrow.” Check your own alternatives before you answer.
If that doesn’t work	Model 9: The Shadow of the Future. Will you deal with them again? A rushed yes teaches them that pressure works. Decide what precedent you want to set.

9. “They say they have a better offer somewhere else”

The game behind it	Model 7: Separate Words From Credibility — They benefit if you believe it. That doesn’t make it false. It makes the statement weaker evidence. Not false. Weaker.
Ask yourself	What do they gain if I believe this? And would they say it anyway?
Try this move	Don’t call it a bluff. Don’t cave either. Ask what the other offer includes and compare on substance.
If that doesn’t work	Model 1: See the Game. Ask what happens if you both walk away. Know your own alternative. If theirs is truly better then let them take it gracefully.

10. “We’re stuck on price and neither side will budge”

The game behind it	Model 2: See the Payoffs — You conflict on price. But you probably agree on getting a deal done. Conflict on one dimension doesn’t mean conflict on everything.
Ask yourself	What do they value that I value less? And what do I value that they value less?
Try this move	Put another dimension on the table. Timing. Payment terms. Scope. If they care most about getting paid fast and you care about paying over time, there’s a deal hiding there.
If that doesn’t work	Model 3: Think in Responses. Reason backward from the end. What will each of you do if this round fails? Choose your next offer with that in mind.

Relationships & Family

11. “We have the same argument every week”

The game behind it	Model 5: See the Equilibrium — You pursue. They withdraw. You pursue harder. They withdraw further. Neither of you is irrational. The pattern is stable.
Ask yourself	Why do we keep ending up here?
Try this move	Name the pattern together without blame. “When I push you pull back. Then I push harder. Can we try one thing differently?” Agree on that one thing.
If that doesn’t work	Model 10: Diagnose the Coordination Problem. If the fight is about logistics then stop renegotiating. Set a simple rule. “Whoever doesn’t do Tuesday handles Thursday.”

12. “They never apologize”

The game behind it	Model 2: See the Payoffs — To them an apology may mean admitting they were entirely at fault. Their payoff includes dignity and self-image. Not just the relationship.
Ask yourself	What does apologizing cost them in their eyes?
Try this move	Make repair cheaper. Separate what happened from who’s to blame. Ask for the specific thing you need going forward.
If that doesn’t work	Model 9: The Shadow of the Future. Look at the history. Have past apologies been used against them later? If so they’ve learned that admitting fault is dangerous. Show them it’s safe now.

13. “My kids ignore every rule I set”

The game behind it	Model 8: Commitment Changes the Game — Six months of grounding sounds strong. But they know you won’t enforce it. Severity is not credibility.
Ask yourself	Will I actually carry this out when the time comes?
Try this move	Swap the big threat for a small consequence you’ll enforce every time. “If the room isn’t clean by six there’s no gaming tonight.” Then follow through.
If that doesn’t work	Model 2: See the Payoffs. Ask what they’re protecting. Your curfew is about safety. Their pushback is about independence. Build a rule that respects both.

14. “I set a boundary and they keep crossing it”

The game behind it	Model 4: Manage Predictability — You said you’d leave if the disrespect continued. Then you stayed. Your pattern taught them the boundary isn’t real.
Ask yourself	What happened the last time they crossed it?
Try this move	State it once and calmly. “We’ll continue this when we can talk respectfully.” Then leave. Every time. No drama.
If that doesn’t work	Model 9: The Shadow of the Future. Ask why you’re still playing this repeated game. A future doesn’t obligate you to stay. Sometimes exit is the long-term strategy.

15. “They haven’t answered my text and I’m spiraling”

The game behind it	Model 6: Map Information & Beliefs — You know very little. Your mind fills the gap with stories. Angry. Busy. Avoiding you. That belief then drives your next move.
Ask yourself	What do I actually know? And what am I assuming?
Try this move	Name three possible explanations. Treat each as a hypothesis. Send one calm follow-up. “No rush. Let me know when works.”
If that doesn’t work	Model 3: Think in Responses. Before the next message ask “Then what?” An anxious text can create the very distance you feared.

Trust & Credibility

16. “They promised and didn’t follow through”

The game behind it	Model 8: Commitment Changes the Game — An intention isn’t a promise. A promise isn’t a commitment. Nothing changed their future options. So when the moment came the easier choice won.
Ask yourself	What actually made that promise binding?
Try this move	Next time agree on the specific step and the date. Add a check-in you’ll both see. Make it easier to follow through than to drift.
If that doesn’t work	Model 7: Separate Words From Credibility. Stop asking “Do I trust them?” Ask “Trust them to do what?” Then adjust what you rely on them for.

17. “Nobody believes my deadlines”

The game behind it	Model 7: Separate Words From Credibility — They understand your words. They just don’t believe them. If you’ve been late before then a better speech won’t fix it. It’s a credibility problem. Not a persuasion problem.
Ask yourself	What reason do they have to believe me?
Try this move	Stop rewording the promise. Offer milestones they can check. Then hit the first one.
If that doesn’t work	Model 9: The Shadow of the Future. Reputation is accumulated information about future behavior. Rebuild it one kept date at a time. Promise less. Deliver every time.

18. “I’m telling the truth and they still want to check everything”

The game behind it	Model 7: Separate Words From Credibility — You know more and you benefit if they believe you. Their checking isn’t an accusation. It’s a response to an information gap.
Ask yourself	If I were in their position what would I need to see?
Try this move	Don’t take offense. Invite the check. Make the truth easy to verify.
If that doesn’t work	Model 6: Map Information & Beliefs. Ask what they already believe about you or people in your role. Address that belief openly and with evidence.

19. “They say I matter. Their actions say otherwise.”

The game behind it	Model 7: Separate Words From Credibility — “I really value this” costs almost nothing to say. Showing up when it’s hard costs something. That’s why actions tell you more.
Ask yourself	Would they say this anyway even if it weren’t true?
Try this move	Tell them what you’ve noticed without attacking. Ask for one concrete thing you can both see.
If that doesn’t work	Model 9: The Shadow of the Future. Watch the pattern over time. If the words never become actions then believe the actions. Decide what you’ll keep investing.

20. “I trusted them once and got burned. Now what?”

The game behind it	Model 9: The Shadow of the Future — There will be a next time. That’s why the next move matters so much. Cooperation doesn’t require defenselessness. Protection doesn’t require a feud.
Ask yourself	Was this a pattern or one mistake in a noisy situation?
Try this move	Respond in proportion. Name what happened. Then rebuild trust in small steps you can verify.
If that doesn’t work	Model 6: Map Information & Beliefs. Check what you actually know about why it happened. If the evidence shows a pattern then protect yourself or step away.

Groups & Coordination

21. “Everyone agrees it’s a problem but nobody acts”

The game behind it	Model 10: Diagnose the Coordination Problem — People aren’t unwilling to act. They’re unwilling to act alone. Going first feels costly when you don’t know who will follow.
Ask yourself	Would they act if they knew the others would too?
Try this move	Make the plan public and mutual. One date. One clear first step. Everyone sees who’s in.
If that doesn’t work	Model 11: Change the Game. If people still hang back once they know the others will act then you’re in a social dilemma. Change what acting costs and what it earns.

22. “Every group plan turns into a long debate”

The game behind it	Model 10: Diagnose the Coordination Problem — Everyone wants to end up together. The exact choice matters less. It’s the dinner problem. Not a real conflict.
Ask yourself	Do we actually want incompatible things? Or do we just need to land on the same thing?
Try this move	Offer a simple default everyone can recognize. “Same place as last time unless someone objects by noon.” A clear focal point beats a perfect option.
If that doesn’t work	Model 2: See the Payoffs. If the debate won’t end then someone may have a real stake. Ask what each person is trying to avoid.

23. “One person never pulls their weight”

The game behind it	Model 10: Diagnose the Coordination Problem — If three roommates will clean anyway the fourth may think “Great. Then I don’t have to.” That’s not a coordination failure. It’s a social dilemma.
Ask yourself	Is this unclear expectations or an individual incentive to coast?
Try this move	Make tasks assigned and visible. Rotate them. Everyone knows the rule before the conflict starts.
If that doesn’t work	Model 11: Change the Game. Redesign the rule so self-interest produces fairness. Like the cake where one cuts and the other chooses.

24. “Everyone stays late because everyone else does”

The game behind it	Model 5: See the Equilibrium — At first the new person wonders why everyone’s still there. Months later they think “If I leave at five people will think I’m not committed.” The game starts playing you.
Ask yourself	What would have to change for this pattern to move?
Try this move	If you lead the group then leave on time where people can see it. Say out loud what you actually expect.
If that doesn’t work	Model 10: Diagnose the Coordination Problem. Many people may want the same change. Nobody wants to go first. Make the new norm public so everyone knows everyone knows.

25. “Two teams blame each other and stopped sharing information”

The game behind it	Model 6: Map Information & Beliefs — One side believed the other would never cooperate. So it stopped sharing. The other side saw that and stopped too. The belief created the proof.
Ask yourself	What does each side believe about the other? And what behavior is feeding that belief?
Try this move	Share something useful first. Say why. Keep the step small and visible.
If that doesn’t work	Model 11: Change the Game. Give both teams a shared result to own. Put a regular handoff in the process so sharing no longer depends on goodwill.

Practice Drill

Read each scenario. Name the model. Pick the move. Then check the key.

Scenario A. Maria runs a small team. In every review she asks, “Any risks I should know about?” Silence. Two weeks later a deadline slips and someone admits they saw it coming.

Scenario B. You’re selling a used piece of equipment. The buyer asks for a discount and you agree. Then they ask for free delivery. Then a spare part. Each time you say yes to keep things friendly.

Scenario C. Three roommates all say the kitchen is a mess. Each one waits for someone else to start the cleaning rota. Nothing happens for a month.

Scenario D. A coworker said “I’ll have the numbers to you Friday” for the third week running. Nothing arrives. You’re about to send a sharp email.

Scenario E. You tell your teenager there will be “serious consequences” if they’re late again. They’re late again. You both know nothing will happen.

Answer key

A. Model 9: The Shadow of the Future. Ask what happened the last time someone raised a risk. Thank the next person who does. Then work it with them.

B. Model 4: Manage Predictability. Your yeses have taught them that asking works. Trade instead of give. “I can do delivery if we keep the price where it is.”

C. Model 10: Diagnose the Coordination Problem. Nobody wants to start alone. Propose one public rota with names and dates. If someone still skips, treat it as a social dilemma and change the rule.

D. Model 8: Commitment Changes the Game. Nothing binds that Friday promise. Agree on a specific handoff and a check-in you’ll both see. Then use Model 7 and ask “Trust them to do what?”

E. Model 8: Commitment Changes the Game. A vague threat you won’t enforce has no credibility. Name one small consequence. Carry it out calmly every time.

Prevent the Problem Before It Starts

Set the rule before the conflict. Most recurring fights come from renegotiating the same thing again and again. Decide who does what and when while everyone is calm. Make it simple and make it shared. A clear convention prevents a dozen arguments.

Watch what your responses teach. Every reaction is a lesson about what comes next. Reward early bad news. Keep the consequences you name. Trade instead of giving things away. Ask “What am I teaching this person to expect from me next time?”

Make truth easy to check. Don’t ask people to take your word for it. Offer milestones. Invite questions. Let your record speak. Credibility built in advance is far cheaper than credibility rebuilt after a miss.

Every move in this matrix should pass one test. **Truth. Autonomy. Dignity. Informed choice.** See the game clearly. Then play it in a way you’d be proud to explain.